



MANITOU SPRINGS, COLORADO – CASE STUDY

ENGAGEMENT: JULY 2020, CASE STUDY – COMMUNITY IN CRISIS

Audience:

- Organizations facing internal (intentional or passive) innovation friction
- Innovation facilitators designing a complex, multi-level (i.e., staff-v-admin), co-designed, shared vision workshop under significant time constraints
- Facilitators in training seeking use cases for various innovation techniques

Innovation tools used: Basic mindsets, co-design canvas, directed improv, gamification, trading cards, analogous thinking, Simplicity, (Basadur) telescoping, challenge mapping, and fun theory

Starting challenge statement: *How might Manitou Springs address the mental health and drug abuse crisis facing the City?*

Situation

Building on previous collaborations with government agencies, including the Indianapolis Metropolitan Police Department, Manitou Spring's Chief of Police, Brian Churchill (formerly of IMPD), requested assistance from Struinova (formerly Compass Consulting) to facilitate the co-design of innovative solutions for the community to address a series of daunting problems. Manitou Springs sits at the base of Pikes Peak and is surrounded by Colorado Springs to the east. The recent and rapid growth of Colorado Springs was pushing homelessness and crime into Manitou Springs.

Homelessness, drug abuse, petty crimes, and a mental health crisis were affecting nearly all aspects of their community. These issues consumed a significant portion of the community's resources, and residents blamed the Mayor and Police Chief. Furthermore, as news of these issues spread, tourism in this tourism-dependent community began to decline. Previous efforts to launch an innovative community strategy were unsuccessful due to a combination of a lack of leadership, minimal government engagement, dismissal by community stakeholders, and outright opposition from others – including some town officials.

Engagement

Manitou Springs hired Struinova to assist the City in finding innovative solutions to these increasingly challenging issues. Struinova's approach was to design and facilitate a workshop with a highly diverse group of approximately 25 individuals from a wide range of organizations, including city officials, all of whom had independent and somewhat self-serving agendas. Struinova and community officials engaged in two pre-workshop sessions to ensure a well-defined problem statement was agreed upon. With a clear understanding of the problem to be solved – a *shared* community-wide vision for success – the workshop was scheduled for July 2020.



STRUINOVA

Agenda

- *Connection Before Content (early morning, day 1)*
In an attempt to set the tone and atmosphere for the two days together, the Struinova team led three fun and simple icebreaker activities that took approximately ten minutes. The goal of the icebreaker activities was to encourage participants to laugh and share, rather than sit and be reserved. Two participants in the workshop were visibly annoyed to have been invited, let alone asked to participate in activities. Unfortunately, one of the participants became annoyed and left before the activity concluded. Her departure was considered by most to be an "acceptable loss."
- *Manitou Success Canvas & Innovation Skills (mid-morning, day 1)*
The Struinova team designed a "Manitou Success Canvas" ("canvas") (like a Business Model Canvas) to help drive the conversation of the workshop. Subsequently, the team designed an intensive, two-day engagement that included teaching basic innovation skills to ensure the community members understood the basic workshop processes. The skills, including divergent thinking, convergent thinking, and deferral of judgment, were explained, followed by a brief exercise for each to ensure participant uptake and a shared common vocabulary for the workshop. The tightly scheduled agenda included subtle "tension breaker" activities to help create a positive, optimistic, goal-focused workshop.
- *Actions to Ensure Participation (mid-morning, post break, day 1)*
With the intention of diffusing personalities and encouraging the City's leadership engagement, the canvas was deployed immediately after the skills onboarding exercises. The goal was to drive a step-by-step co-design process *and* to abstract the City's challenges into a target on the wall, rather than focusing on individual personalities and agendas. Furthermore, several executive-level city administrators who had chosen not to participate in the two-day workshop also participated in the co-design process. By lunchtime on the first day, the previously prominent individual silos and agendas were significantly reduced.
- *Gamification of Innovation Development (Noon, lunch break, day 1)*
The Struinova team designed the workshop agenda to gamify the innovation process and outcomes. With input from engaged city leaders, the large group was split into two teams to ensure a competitive environment. The teams were not intentionally homogeneous in their opinions. The teams were announced before the lunch break and were encouraged to use the last several minutes of the lunch break for (re)introductions, collaboration, and goal setting. The teams were encouraged to treat their innovative strategies as secret until the expected presentations at the conclusion of day two. They were informed that they would prepare and present their approaches to solving the City's challenges during the workshop on the following day.



STRUINOVA

- *Innovation Sessions: Improv & Analogous Thinking (early afternoon, day 1)*
With the group split, the Struinova team divided their efforts to facilitate parallel activities. The first group initiated its work with improv skits that portrayed both the current state and the future (successful) state of the City's culture. All members of the group participated in both skits under the pretense that it would not be recorded. The key ideas identified during the skits were captured and enumerated. The second group worked through three iterations of an analogous thinking exercise, with the first iteration based on a fictitious and outlandish comparative scenario to open the group's imagination. The second and third iterations were grounded in reality. The Struinova team helped identify and preserve the novel findings from three iterations for subsequent use.
 - *Afternoon Break (mid-afternoon, day 1)*
During the mid-afternoon break, participants exchanged "trading cards" of everyone in the workshop to create a dream team for two fictitious scenarios. This fun theory approach to team building proved to be highly effective and an invaluable tool for building community and reducing internal friction.
 - *Fact Finding & Solution Identification (post-break, afternoon, day 1)*
After the activity, the groups reconvened and began generating an exhaustive list of facts surrounding the challenges facing Manitou to seed the following day's work using Simplexity.
 - *Popcorn Debrief (conclusion, day 1)*
After the first day, each participant briefly shared, without revealing team secrets, one or two key takeaways from the day's work. One takeaway was required to be funny, the second serious. The City provided a casual buffet meal for those who could stay – most participants stayed for at least 30 minutes before departing.
-
- *Yes, And Warmup (start, day 2)*
To ensure the momentum and enthusiasm gained during day one continued to flourish, and to start the day in the right mood (laughing vs. somber), the Struinova team led a modified version of the "Yes And" improv activity. The Struinova team combined the Yes And activity with a popcorn (rapid) approach to generating responses. The group was divided into two parts (not previously assigned teams) to promote engagement and participation. The groups were arranged in a circle, and every member was expected to participate twice per round. The two rounds were seeded with the questions "What would happen if gold were discovered in Manitou?" and "What are two things you'd do if aliens landed in Manitou?"
 - *Problem Definition, Simplexity Step Three (early morning, day 2)*
The teams returned to their breakout rooms. Using the facts generated from the previous afternoon, the Struinova team led the groups through the third



step in the Simplicityⁱ process (problem definition). This step consumed the balance of the morning session, leading to the lunch break. For both groups, a specific "problem" was identified to advance to the afternoon sessions. The problem definitions diverged significantly from the original challenge statement—a typical result of a successful Simplicity exercise.

- *Decompress Lunch (day 2)*
Sensing the opportunity to leverage perfect weather and a nearby park, the Struinova team requested that the City's support team move the lunch from the large gathering room to the park on the other side of a nearby stream. The two teams needed a break from the heavy morning workload. Not surprisingly, many of the day one "adversaries" were sharing tables. The participants were not seated at their team's tables, and many of the conversations centered on the work of their group; yet, they sought to maintain the secrecy of their group's work and competitiveness.
- *Idea Finding, Simplicity Steps Four & Five (early afternoon, day 2)*
Following the Simplicity methodology - step four, the teams began generating possible ideas to address the problem definition from the previous afternoon (Simplicity step three). Each of the groups generated five actionable and solid ideas (Simplicity step four) and prioritized implementation for each using a variety of methods (Simplicity step five).
- *Afternoon Break (mid-afternoon, day 2)*
The Struinova team and the Chief of Police visited a local restaurant the day before the workshop. In a casual conversation with the restaurant owner, he offered to provide energy drinks and energy snacks for the workshop attendees. He graciously delivered the snacks to the park next door.
- *Presentation Preparation (mid-afternoon, day 2)*
The groups were given thirty minutes to prepare a five-minute presentation to share with the larger group. The presentation aimed to include key takeaways from each activity and step of the workshop, along with a summary of the previously ranked implementation steps. The Struinova team timed the presentations to ensure there was ample time remaining for the next steps. The two teams had vastly divergent ideas and implementation steps, encouraging creativity in a blended next steps agenda. (Note: the Struinova team privately discussed the divergent ideas after hours and during breaks, but never disclosed or swayed the direction of a given team's work.)
- *Implementation Steps (mid-afternoon, day 2)*
The Struinova team compiled the results of the presentations as they were given. The larger group's enthusiasm and inclination were optimistic. Absent were the stifling tensions so prevalent at the start of day one of the workshop. See the outcomes of the implementation steps in the Results section of this document below.



STRUINOVA

- *Conclusion and Debrief (end of day 2)*

Day two concluded on time as planned at 4:45 pm. The Struinova team led a recap of the two-day workshop, highlighting the group's key outputs and the remarkable presentations from earlier in the day.

The participants stated that initially, they anticipated a failed outcome from the workshop – that it would be a waste of time. They did not expect the outcomes of the two-day workshop.

The Chief of Police and Mayor of Manitou Springs thanked the participants. Both the City's staff and the Struinova team were optimistic that the workshop would lead to positive outcomes and organized a small celebratory party. Most of the participants remained at the celebration until 5:30 (and helped clean up).

Results

The following is a summary of the results of the two-day workshop in Manitou Springs. Many participants were business owners, nonprofit leaders, and a few wealthy families.

- The group determined that a wellness and behavioral health center was necessary in Manitou.
- One of the workshop participants owned a mostly vacant building and generously offered significantly reduced rent for the initiative to use the space for the first year. It would require a nominal amount of renovation.
- A generous participant stepped up to cover the nominal renovation costs.
- The center was named *The BeeHive*.
- Several participants initiated the creation of a foundation to help fund the BeeHive and committed to conducting a fundraising campaign.
- A local mental health organization (Aspen Pointe) stepped up to provide two social workers as soon as the facility was open. Previously, individuals seeking mental health assistance or taken into aid by the Manitou police had a thirty-minute drive to the southeastern corner of Colorado Springs.
- A local charitable group covered the costs of utilities and receptionist compensation for the first six months.
- The group set a deadline for the filing of a 501(c)(3) application to the IRS, and an individual stepped in to ensure its completion.

Fast forward six months:

- The Hive, as its name had become, was successfully launched within two months after the workshop.
- A group of volunteers from the workshop assisted in developing preliminary job descriptions for the volunteers.
- Members of the community stepped up to serve on the board of directors. They developed the necessary bylaws, mission statements, and other key documents. (Note: The Struinova team later learned that the directors came from several previously competing "camps" and were successfully working together.)



STRUINOVA

- Activity at the Hive was significant, and the Manitou police were making regular referrals and/or introductions to the Hive staff.
- The staff, board, police, and City leadership co-developed SOPs to manage the operations, intake processes, referral methods, and dismissal/release steps.

Conclusion

The outcome of the City of Manitou Springs' investment with StruinoVA (then Compass Consulting) and the participants' investment of time in the two-day workshop produced remarkable results. Chief Churchill's quote best described the results:

"The Hive has been met with great enthusiasm and support from the community. It will be one of the cornerstones of Manitou Springs once it is up and running, all because of how the community conceived it. The training provided and process used by Compass Consulting (now StruinoVA Innovation) reframed the needs, created community support, made everyone feel like stakeholders, and built confidence among community members that they would accomplish their shared vision and goals. The training also taught participants how to work through difficult issues and come to resolutions everyone could agree on."

StruinoVA's approach was to both facilitate and teach the participants some fundamental innovation and problem-solving skills and techniques. An anticipated benefit of this approach was recognized when individual participants took their newly acquired skills and innovative attitude back to their respective organizations to address opportunities for innovation. These new skills and confidence created an expanded vision and optimism to tackle additional challenges in the community. City leadership reported that several workshop participants had applied their newfound skills to subsequent projects in other public/private initiatives.

About StruinoVA

For more information on this case study, the innovation techniques/skills deployed in this engagement, or StruinoVA Innovation, please contact Ron Brumbarger - ron@struinoVA.com, phone - 317.490.4376. StruinoVA Innovation is an Indianapolis-based professional innovation facilitation and innovation-as-a-service provider.

ⁱ Simplicity – Basadur Innovation / <https://basadur.com>